beautiful conversation two people can ever have with each other:

‘I think I’m in love with you, Victoria.’

‘I think I’m in love with you, too.’

Keeping it all to ourselves wasn’t exactly my choice but I respected the way things had to be for Victoria. I’d stepped into Spiceworld and understood how important the Girls and their management team felt it was to keep everything under control. I didn’t talk to anyone about what was happening between us. My parents were aware something was going on but, at United, I wasn’t going to be a lad who came into the dressing room one morning boasting that he was going out with a pop star. That wasn’t me. I remember turning up for training one Monday after a lovely weekend with Victoria and Ben Thornley asking me why I was in such a good mood.

‘I’ve met this lovely girl.’

‘Who?’

‘Oh, just this lovely girl who lives down in London.’

Rumors started anyway. I suppose that was bound to happen. And rumors are something we’ve lived with ever since. It wasn’t long after our relationship became public that Victoria was getting phone calls to say the papers had pictures of me kissing another girl in my car. Those kinds of stories—completely untrue—still turn up now and again. Of course, proving something’s not true is a lot harder than proving it is. We’ve got used to rumors, though, and how and why they happen. We had to almost from the start. Victoria and I trusted each other then, just as we do now. If you’re with someone you love, you know anyway, deep down, what’s real and what isn’t.

With all the gossip doing the rounds, it got to the point where I had half a dozen photographers camped outside my house in Worsley every day, just waiting for Victoria to turn up. I’d never experienced anything like this before, whereas Victoria had, of course. I think she made the decision, really. She phoned to say she was coming up to see me and that she was happy enough to stop all the secrecy. We knew what we meant to each other, didn’t we? It was better that we decided where and when the public found out for sure that we were together. People imagine ours has been a glitzy, showbiz romance. Just remember: the first photos of us together were taken when we were walking down my road to go to the newsstand on the corner.